THE SMART AGENT'S GUIDE TO

Hiring a Transaction Coordinator

Know what to look for. Ask better questions.
Find the right support for your real estate business.

DELEGATE WITH INTENTION.

A stronger operating model starts with better hiring decisions.

A CEO-to-CEO workbook for
Florida real estate professionals.

HOME TOWN
TRANSACTION COORDINATORS

WELCOME · A NOTE FROM MICHELLE

Before You Hand Over Your Next Contract...

The right support creates room for the work only you can do.

You can be excellent at generating business, nurturing relationships, showing properties, and negotiating contracts—and still feel stretched by everything that happens after the signatures.

A capable coordinator helps organize the administrative movement of a transaction. The wrong fit can leave you with even more follow-up to supervise.

I created this guide to help you evaluate the person, the process, and the working relationship—not simply compare a fee. Use it whether you choose an employee, an independent coordinator, or a team.



Michelle Martinez
Founder, Hometown Transaction Coordinators

> “The right support should give you more confidence, not more work to supervise.”

Start with your own needs. Ask every finalist the same questions. Then look for evidence in a real file.

Michelle Martinez

Founder · Florida real estate experience since 1995.

YOUR ROADMAP

Your Roadmap to the Right TC

01 **Before You Hire** 04–05
Define the job before you look for a person.

02 **Know Your Options** 06–07
Compare operating models, not labels.

03 **What Great Coordination Looks Like** 08–09
Recognize ownership, follow-up, and escalation.

04 **The Interview Playbook** 10–13
Ask for process—and test it with real scenarios.

05 **Compare Your Candidates** 14–15
Use evidence, written scope, and a weighted scorecard.

06 **Your First 30 Days** 16–17
Start with a clear handoff and review real activity.

07 **Your Next Move** 18–21
Make your decision and explore the right fit.

Make this workbook yours. Complete the assessment first, interview consistently, compare evidence, and agree on responsibilities in writing. Worksheets are designed for handwritten responses.

What Do You Actually Need Help With?

Being busy is a symptom. Your next hire should address the actual source of friction.

Separate document collection from transaction management, client updates from decision-making, and brokerage requirements from assumptions about “full service.”

Administrative support

Collecting documents, organizing files, entering information, and scheduling agreed administrative tasks. Useful when the main bottleneck is paperwork.

Contract-to-close coordination

A repeatable intake process, contract-specific date tracking, follow-up with responsible parties, and timely escalation to the agent.

Broker compliance support

Organizing required documents and surfacing missing items in your brokerage’s system. Confirm your broker’s requirements and who reviews or approves the file.

Expanded transaction & client care

Defined milestone updates, next-step reminders, and coordination with transaction participants. Clarify which communications need the agent’s approval.

> **The goal isn’t to delegate everything. It’s to delegate the right things.**

The friction I most want to remove

01 / WORKSHEET

Let's Look at Your Business

Answer from your actual workflow—not the business you hope to have someday.

Average monthly transactions / active files

Budget / anticipated growth

Property types handled

☐ Cash ☐ Financed ☐ Condo / co-op ☐ HOA ☐ Luxury ☐ Other

Most time-consuming administrative tasks

Current transaction management process

Biggest communication frustrations / language needs

Desired involvement after going under contract

☐ Every update ☐ Exceptions only ☐ Defined checkpoints

Support hours / urgent-response expectations

Brokerage systems, compliance requirements / approval owner

My Three Non-Negotiables

Not All Transaction Coordination Looks the Same

These are operating models, not quality rankings. Verify the actual person, process, and agreement.

In-house TC

Best suited for: Steady work that benefits from close, direct oversight. **Advantages:** Dedicated capacity and familiarity with your operation.

Potential limitations: Salary, benefits, training, and absence coverage.

Clarify: Who trains, supervises, and covers the role?

Independent TC

Best suited for: Agents seeking a direct working relationship. **Advantages:** Personal continuity and focused transaction experience.

Potential limitations: Capacity or availability may depend on one person.

Clarify: Who owns the file when you are out?

Transaction coordination agency

Best suited for: Agents who want a structured team workflow. **Advantages:** Standardized processes and potential team coverage.

Potential limitations: Handoffs and the point of contact may vary.

Clarify: Who is my primary coordinator and backup?

Virtual administrative assistant

Best suited for: A focused administrative workload. **Advantages:** Flexible help with defined recurring tasks.

Potential limitations: Contract familiarity and supervision needs vary.

Clarify: What Florida transaction experience can you demonstrate?

Licensed agent providing transaction support

Best suited for: A defined support role that may involve licensed work. **Advantages:** May bring contract experience and licensed capabilities.

Potential limitations: Authority, brokerage role, compensation, and conflicts need review.

Clarify: What is your role, affiliation, and authorized scope?

> Administrative support is not a substitute for licensed representation, legal advice, or the agent's supervision. Confirm authority and supervision with your broker; do not infer them from a job title.

02 / COMPARE YOUR OPTIONS

Which Support Model Fits Your Business?

Use this matrix to structure the conversation. No model earns an automatic advantage.

Compare	In-house	Independent	Agency	Virtual assistant	Licensed agent
Cost structure	Salary / benefits	Ask per-side or retainer	Ask package / per-side	Ask hourly / retainer	Ask role / compensation
Coverage & backup	Arrange internally	Verify named backup	Verify team handoffs	Verify backup access	Verify competing duties
Contract experience	Assess and train	Request examples	Assess assigned TC	Do not assume	Verify relevant files
Client communication	Define voice / scope	Define approvals	Confirm point of contact	Define scripts / limits	Separate support role
Brokerage familiarity	Train to your system	Test system knowledge	Confirm broker process	Define supervision	Confirm affiliation
Scalability	Plan staffing needs	Ask capacity limits	Ask assignment process	Ask available hours	Ask competing volume
Availability	Set work schedule	Agree hours / urgency	Confirm coverage hours	Agree time zone / hours	Agree response targets
Onboarding	Recruit, train, grant access	Align tools / intake	Align team / workflow	Train tasks / security	Clarify role / access

> Services, fee structures, experience, and capabilities vary by provider. Every item above requires confirmation—not an assumption.

My most practical model—and what I still need to verify

A Great TC Does More Than Move Paperwork

Every transaction has moving parts. Great coordination makes the deadlines, responsibilities, and next steps visible.

01 Executed Contract

Receive the signed agreement, applicable riders, and amendments.

02 Intake & File Setup

Confirm parties, contacts, documents, missing items, and responsibilities.

03 Critical Dates

Establish the contract-specific timeline and identify approaching deadlines.

04 Inspection & Financing

Follow open items, requests, and milestones applicable to the transaction.

05 Association & Title

Track application status, approvals, documentation, and title-related requests.

06 Broker Compliance

Identify outstanding requirements and coordinate readiness for broker review.

07 Closing & File Completion

Coordinate final deliverables, closing logistics, and file closeout.

OPEN LOOPS · THROUGHOUT THE JOURNEY

IDENTIFY → FOLLOW UP → VERIFY ↺

A task remains open until the required response, document, confirmation, or next action is recorded. Track the responsible party; not every task belongs to the TC.

CASH SINGLE-FAMILY

Typically fewer financing-related milestones.

FINANCED CONDOMINIUM

May involve lender requirements, condominium documents, association approval, insurance, and additional coordination.

Transactions do not all follow the same path. The actual checklist depends on the executed contract, amendments, property type, representation, and agreed service scope.

Reactive Support vs. Proactive Oversight

Look beyond activity. Look for ownership of the next action.

OUTSTANDING TASKS

REACTIVE SUPPORT

"Let me know when you need something."

PROACTIVE OVERSIGHT

"Here's what's outstanding, who's responsible, and when we need it."

ASSOCIATION APPLICATION

REACTIVE SUPPORT

"Did the buyer complete the association application?"

PROACTIVE OVERSIGHT

"Application status checked, missing items identified, and responsible party followed up with."

CLOSING READINESS

REACTIVE SUPPORT

"Closing is next week."

PROACTIVE OVERSIGHT

"Closing readiness reviewed, outstanding items escalated, and responsible parties updated."

The difference isn't who sends the email. It's who keeps the loop moving.

Look for evidence: a tracker, a documented follow-up, an assigned responsibility, and a clear escalation process.

Illustrative service behaviors—not promises made by every TC.

What would proactive support change in my business?

Ten Questions Worth Asking Before You Hire

Ask every finalist the same ten questions. Request a specific example or demonstration.

Candidate: _____ Date: _____

01 / PROCESS & EXPERIENCE

01 Walk me through your intake process from executed contract to a verified timeline.

What to listen for: Complete documents, verified dates, assigned responsibilities.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

02 / DEADLINES & ESCALATION

02 How do you handle a deadline that is near but a responsible party has not responded?

What to listen for: Contract-specific monitoring, documented follow-up, timely escalation.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

03 How do you handle a contract amendment or changed closing date across all trackers?

What to listen for: Version control and synchronized dates across all trackers.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

04 Tell me about a transaction problem you escalated early. What did you document and what was the outcome?

What to listen for: Early warning, documented facts, agent escalation, and lessons learned.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

03 / COMMUNICATION & CLIENT CARE

05 What does your weekly agent update include, and when is it sent?

What to listen for: A predictable cadence, open items, owners, and next actions.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

Ten Questions Worth Asking Before You Hire

Ask every finalist the same ten questions. Request a specific example or demonstration.

Candidate: _____ Date: _____

03 / COMMUNICATION & CLIENT CARE · CONTINUED

06 Which client communications are included, and which require the agent's approval?

What to listen for: Defined client contact, approval rules, and professional boundaries.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

07 How would you manage an association application and approval on a financed condo?

What to listen for: Application ownership, missing items, status checks, agent updates.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

04 / COMPLIANCE & SECURITY

08 How do you prepare a file for brokerage compliance and track missing items?

What to listen for: Broker-specific requirements, missing-item tracking, review ownership.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

09 How do you protect confidential documents and avoid sending wire instructions?

What to listen for: Secure access, confidentiality safeguards, no wire instructions.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

05 / CAPACITY, COVERAGE & SERVICE SCOPE

10 What happens when you are out, at capacity, or handling multiple urgent files?

What to listen for: Named backup, capacity limits, and urgent-file prioritization.

CANDIDATE RESPONSE

Confirm service scope separately: Included tasks, extras, fees, cancellation and payment terms, hours, response targets, and required brokerage approvals.

Don’t Just Ask What They Know. Ask What They Would Do.

Ask the candidate to walk through the next actions—not just describe the problem.

A

SCENARIO A — LOAN APPROVAL DEADLINE

The lender has not provided a clear update and the deadline is approaching. **What do you do, document, and escalate?**

Listen For ☐ Clear process ☐ Responsibility tracking
☐ Timely escalation ☐ Documentation ☐ Professional boundaries

CANDIDATE NOTES

B

SCENARIO B — ASSOCIATION APPROVAL

Closing is approaching and association approval is still outstanding. **How do you identify the risk, communicate status, and follow up?**

Listen For ☐ Clear process ☐ Responsibility tracking
☐ Timely escalation ☐ Documentation ☐ Professional boundaries

CANDIDATE NOTES

C

SCENARIO C — LAST-MINUTE CLOSING ISSUE

The closing agent reports missing information shortly before closing. **What is your immediate response and communication plan?**

Listen For ☐ Clear process ☐ Responsibility tracking
☐ Timely escalation ☐ Documentation ☐ Professional boundaries

CANDIDATE NOTES

Boundary question: A seller requests new contract terms directly from the TC. How would you respond?
Listen for referral of negotiation and contractual decisions to the appropriate licensed professional—not negotiation or legal advice by the coordinator.

What Their Answers Are Really Telling You

Green flags

Look for evidence you can see.

- ☐ Explains a repeatable process
- ☐ Tracks contract-specific critical dates
- ☐ Defines communication expectations
- ☐ Knows when and how to escalate
- ☐ Understands role boundaries
- ☐ Has a backup or coverage plan
- ☐ Protects confidential information

Red flags

Pause and ask for clarity.

- ☐ Cannot explain deadline tracking
- ☐ Makes unrealistic guarantees
- ☐ Has unclear service boundaries
- ☐ Lacks a backup plan
- ☐ Cannot explain file documentation
- ☐ Avoids discussing fees or capacity
- ☐ Suggests unauthorized licensed activities

> **A reference check is part of the interview.** Ask: Did updates arrive proactively? What happened when a file became complicated? Were fees and boundaries clear? Would you hire this person or team again—and why?

Evidence I want to see before deciding

05 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON SCORECARD

Compare Candidates With Confidence

Rate each area from **1** (weak or unverified) to **5** (clear, demonstrated strength). Use evidence, not charm.

Candidate A _____ **Candidate B** _____ **Candidate C** _____

Evaluation criterion	Weight	A	B	C
Contract / Process Fluency	25%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Proactive Follow-Up & Escalation	20%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Communication & Client Care	20%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Capacity, Backup & Reliability	15%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Compliance & Security Practices	10%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Scope, Pricing & Fit	10%	___ / 5	___ / 5	___ / 5
Weighted total	**100%**	**___ /100**	**___ /100**	**___ /100**

(Category Rating ÷ 5) × Category Weight = Weighted Points

A candidate receiving 4 out of 5 in a category weighted at 25% earns 20 points. Add all six categories for a total out of 100.

My Leading Candidate

What I Still Need to Verify

My Final Decision

Get Clear on What's Included

The agreement should describe the working relationship as clearly as the service.

- [ ] **Exact scope of work**
  Included and excluded tasks; transaction types; extra services.
- [ ] **Client communication responsibilities**
  Who contacts whom, approved language, and agent approvals.
- [ ] **Hours and response expectations**
  Business hours, urgent channel, and response targets.
- [ ] **File intake requirements**
  Required documents, contacts, delivery, and start-of-service trigger.
- [ ] **Brokerage compliance responsibilities**
  Systems, document collection, review, and approval ownership.
- [ ] **Fees and cancellation terms**
  Per-side or other fees, payment timing, extras, and cancellation.
- [ ] **Backup coverage**
  Named backup, access, handoff process, and capacity limits.
- [ ] **Escalation procedures**
  What is escalated, to whom, through which channel, and when.
- [ ] **Data access and confidentiality**
  Secure access, storage, retention, and access revocation.
- [ ] **Termination and file handoff**
  File ownership, open-item summary, and transition responsibilities.

> Review the agreement with your broker and qualified advisers as appropriate. A vague "full-service" label is not a substitute for defined responsibilities.

Start With One Smooth Handoff

Agree on who does what before the first deadline. A first-file trial tests the process, not a promise.

01 Before Intake

- [ ] **Agent**
  Confirm scope, pricing, approvals, broker permission, contacts, and secure platform access.
- [ ] **TC**
  Confirm intake requirements, backup, response targets, escalation route, and document safeguards.

02 Contract Received

- [ ] **Agent**
  Deliver the executed agreement, riders, amendments, and complete contacts; review the proposed date timeline.
- [ ] **TC**
  Confirm receipt, identify missing items, prepare a contract-specific tracker, and assign open-loop owners.

03 Active Transaction

- [ ] **Agent**
  Review the first update for accuracy and voice; make decisions and approve notices or addenda as agreed.
- [ ] **TC**
  Follow unanswered requests, update all trackers after changes, escalate exceptions, and track compliance items.

04 Closing and Review

- [ ] **Agent**
  Confirm agent-owned decisions and logistics; review the experience and identify one improvement.
- [ ] **TC**
  Coordinate remaining deliverables, record unresolved items, and organize file closeout and agreed handoff.

One handoff detail we must agree on before starting

Is Your New Support Actually Working?

Evaluate after the first file or first 30 days—whichever provides enough real activity. A short pilot is more informative than a perfect sales pitch.

Week 1 · Setup and expectations

Check intake accuracy: parties, dates, contacts, and documents. Confirm roles, channels, and approval rules.

Week 2 · Communication and follow-up

Are updates predictable and sent to the right people? Does follow-up continue until open loops are resolved?

Week 3 · Consistency and accountability

Are exceptions escalated early? Are missing compliance items surfaced with time for the agent to act?

Week 4 · Performance and fit

Do clients know next steps while the agent stays central? Identify extra work created and one change for the next file.

What is working?

What still needs improvement?

What should change?

Continue, adjust, or reconsider?

☐ Continue ☐ Continue with adjustments ☐ Reassess provider

> The review period evaluates the working relationship. It does not assume every transaction type or file volume will reach closing within 30 days.

07 / YOUR DECISION PAGE

The Right TC Should Make Your Business Easier to Run

Choose support that fits your clients, your responsibilities, and the way you work.

My preferred support model

My top three requirements

My preferred communication cadence

My budget

My target start date

My next action / decision date

- [ ] I understand the scope, task owners, approvals, exceptions, and backup plan.
- [ ] I have seen evidence of process—not just promises.

> The right transaction coordinator isn't simply another expense. They're part of how you deliver a consistent client experience.

Smooth Closings. Period.

At Hometown Transaction Coordinators, we believe great support should give agents more room to do what they do best: build relationships, serve clients, and grow their business.



Founded by Michelle Martinez, HTC brings decades of Florida real estate experience to a structured approach to contract-to-close coordination.

Our work is built around clear timelines, proactive follow-up, thoughtful communication, and attention to the details that keep transactions moving.

THE HOME VALUES

H

HONOR

Respect the trust and responsibilities behind every transaction.

O

ORDER

Create clarity around deadlines, documents, and next steps.

M

MASTERY

Apply experience, sound processes, and attention to detail.

E

EASE

Make the transaction experience easier for agents and their clients.

What Makes HTC Different?

- Experienced Florida real estate oversight
- Proactive transaction tracking and follow-up
- Brokerage compliance coordination
- Agent-first client communication
- Structured systems and defined responsibilities

HTC's service approach is subject to the applicable service agreement.

07 / YOUR NEXT STEP

You've Done the Homework. Let's Talk About Your Business.

You know what to look for in transaction support. Now let's explore what that could look like for your business.

In a 15-minute HTC Fit Call, we'll discuss your current workflow, transaction volume, communication preferences, and the kind of support that would make the greatest difference.

YOUR BUSINESS. YOUR WORKFLOW. YOUR NEXT STEP.

BOOK YOUR 15-MINUTE FIT CALL

www.hometowntc.com/book

No pressure. Just a practical conversation about your business and whether HTC is the right fit.

> ## Stay Booked. Blessed. And Out of Breach.

CLARITY. ACCOUNTABILITY. CONFIDENCE.

Hometown Transaction Coordinators

Smooth Closings. Period.

www.hometowntc.com

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